

Reflection on “Graphic Novel: Motherhood in Crisis”

In many parts of the world, childbirth is seen as a joyful event and a symbol of life’s continuation. Yet in Sierra Leone, giving birth often becomes a dangerous journey that many women do not survive. Al Jazeera’s 2020 feature “Motherhood in crisis”, presented as a graphic narrative, reveals the harsh realities faced by women during childbirth. Through the stories of four women—Maimunatu, Heela, Kadiatu, and Tetteh—the piece exposes how fragile healthcare systems, social inequality, and gender discrimination turn motherhood into a life-threatening experience.

Sierra Leone’s high maternal mortality rate has taken the lives of thousands of women. Nearly one in ten women die during childbirth, a number that reflects not only the lack of medical resources but also deep-rooted structural and cultural issues. Maimunatu’s story allows us to feel her suffering directly. Living in a remote village, she must travel long distances on rough roads without reliable transportation. Access to professional care becomes an unreachable privilege. It makes me realize how easily many people elsewhere take safe and accessible healthcare for granted.

Heela’s story highlights another layer of this crisis—the vicious cycle between poverty and gender inequality. She is a young girl forced to drop out of school because of pregnancy. In Sierra Leone, girls face heavy social pressure and limited educational opportunities. Once pregnant, they are often banned from returning to school, which destroys their chances for a better future. Heela’s experience illustrates how gender inequality is reproduced generation after generation, as women are denied both education and autonomy. It also reflects how society tends to punish women for circumstances beyond their control while ignoring the systemic failures that make such situations inevitable.

Kadiatu’s grief after losing her child reveals the emotional trauma that comes with this health crisis. The pain of losing a baby should never be normalized, yet in Sierra Leone, such tragedies are frequent and often met with silence. The community’s emotional detachment and the lack of

psychological support make these women's suffering even more isolating. Their losses are treated as unfortunate but ordinary, which shows how deeply inequality has shaped the way people perceive pain and value life.

Tetteh's experience as a pregnant prisoner exposes the extreme vulnerability of women who are already marginalized. Her story shows how poverty, gender, and imprisonment intersect to deny women basic care and dignity. Inside the prison, her pregnancy is treated not with compassion but as an inconvenience, revealing how the system often dehumanizes women in custody. Tetteh's suffering is not only personal but symbolic—it speaks to the invisible layers of oppression faced by women who exist at the margins of society. Her story forces us to confront uncomfortable truths about justice and humanity: that neglect, rather than violence, is often the quietest form of cruelty.

Reading *Motherhood in Crisis* made me reflect deeply on the meaning of equality and care. It is not only a story about Sierra Leone but also a mirror that reflects global injustice in maternal health. Motherhood should never be a test of survival; it should be a universal right to safety, dignity, and compassion that every woman deserves.